

Dominant & Counter Narratives

Warm-up:

Marjorie Anecdote

Marjorie Thompson is racist.

She is a 93 year old white woman. Marjorie went to school in a rural area of upstate New York. In the town where she grew up, there were no families of color. Marjorie went to school with only white children and she only ever had white teachers. The police officers, mail carriers, store clerks and farmers in her community were all white. She was 45 years old the first time she ever met a person of color. Marjorie grew up watching a lot of television. She grew up watching the news every night, TV shows and movies. She listens to music on a local radio station and reads a popular national newspaper. Her daughter recently signed her up for Facebook and she is “friends” with a few of the gals she grew up with.

Why do you think Marjorie is racist? Where did Marjorie's ideas come from? What's the problem with this?

Mini-Lesson:

Define dominant culture

What is the dominant culture of the US?

Activities:

-Dom narrative intro: I see I think I wonder

[Fort Apache Trailer](#) (How does this film seem to describe the Bronx and its inhabitants?)

-Dominant Culture Gallery Walk: I see, I think, I wonder

(Images, photos and headlines taken from mainstream media)

-What story does the dominant narrative tell about the Bronx?

Counter Narrative Station Rotation:

-Station 1: Images from Bronx Photographers

-Station 2: Headlines from local News Sources (Written by Bronx Residents)

-Station 3: The We and the I (a film starring local teens - who had input into the writing of the script)

-What differences did we see between the texts produced by the dominant culture/outside vs. people who actually live here?

-What does the dominant narrative seem to leave out or miss?

-positive stories/aspects

-What people of the Bronx actually need to know about or are struggling with / what

Name: _____

residents are fighting for

-Does the counter-narrative ONLY show the positive side?

How might we define the dominant narrative? Counter narrative?

Mini-lesson:

Dominant Narrative- (Who tells the story? What is usually missing from this story?)

Counter-Narrative- (Who tells the story?)

Which narrative is probably told more often? Which story holds more weight/clout?

How might the dominant narrative be harmful to people or a community? What “stereotypes” might be created by the dominant story?

-blames people for their own situation

-folks might not get attention/help

-denigrates a people's humanity

-reinforces harmful/racist stereotypes

How might counter-narratives *resist* or fight back against the dominant narrative?

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Writing:

How did the story told through the Counter-narrative differ from the dominant narrative? Which story is most accurate/true?

Next Lesson:

How can/do we tell counter narratives?

- Genres - photography project

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Name: _____

Student-Facing Handouts Below

Name: _____

Dominant & Counter Narratives

Warm-up: [Anecdote](#)

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**Why do you think Marjorie is racist? Where did Marjorie’s ideas come from?
What’s the problem with this?**

Mini-Lesson: Vocabulary

Vocab Word	Definition	Response
Dominant Culture		<i>Who determines the dominant culture in America?</i>

Name: _____

Dominant Culture on The Bronx

“Fort Apache, The Bronx” [Film Trailer](#)

I see... What observations can you make?	I think... What do you think is going on? What comments can you make?	I wonder... What questions are raised for you?

Dominant Culture [Gallery Walk](#) Debrief:

a. Choose one “slide” that stood out to you. What does it show? What does it say about the Bronx?	
b. What were some common images or ideas that were repeated throughout the gallery walk?	
c. What are some questions this gallery walk raised for you?	

Name: _____

Dominant Narrative¹ about The Bronx

After viewing the film trailer and gallery walk, **what is the story told** by the dominant culture about the Bronx? *Be sure to use specific details/evidence to support your answer.*

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no handwriting or other markings on the paper.¹ Narrative: Story

Name: _____

Counter-Narrative Station Rotation

Station	I think... I wonder... <i>What observations, comments or questions do you have?</i>	Response
<u>Station 1:</u> Images/Photos	• • • •	What is one image that stood out to you? Describe it and explain why it stood out.
<u>Station 2:</u> Headlines	• • • •	What types of stories are being covered by Bronx reporters? How did these headlines compare to the dominant culture headlines?
<u>Station 3:</u> Film Trailer: “The We and the I”	• • • •	What might you guess is the overall message of this film?

Name: _____

Mini-Lesson: Vocabulary

Dominant Narrative	Counter Narrative

Group Discussion: Notes

Jot down notes from your discussion. Bullets are fine, no need for whole sentences.

1	
2	
3	
4	
5	

Name: _____

The Bronx Counter-Narrative

What is missing from the dominant narrative about the Bronx?

How can counter narratives help us see the whole story?

Be sure to use specific details/evidence to support your answer.

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Name: _____